

Plan — Big Muddy Records

Owner: Chase Pierson Status: Pre-revenue. Long-term play. Last updated: 2026-04-29

What it is

Big Muddy Records is the label arm of the Big Muddy ecosystem — a record label rooted in Mississippi blues and the broader corridor sound. We own bigmuddyrecordlabel.com and operate the label as a long-horizon brand asset, not a near-term revenue line.

What's working today

Almost nothing yet. Be honest about it.

- Domain is live and routes correctly.
- Roster page exists with Mechanical Bull and Arrie Aslin listed (Mechanical Bull = Chase's catalog, Arrie = band project).
- "Artist platform" CTA on the records page links to bigmuddyrecordlabel.com.
- No releases shipped under the Big Muddy Records imprint.
- No distribution deal in place.
- No PRO/publisher administration set up.
- No revenue.

What we have: a name, a domain, a roster page, and three Mechanical Bull masters sitting on a hard drive waiting to be remastered.

The economics

Records is a 12–24 month gestation play. Realistic revenue forecast for the next 12 months: **\$0**.

Year 1 cost (estimate):

- Mastering (3 records, outside engineer): 1,500–3,000
- Distribution setup (DistroKid or Symphonic): 20–300

- ISRC codes + barcodes: included with distributor
- PRO registration (BMI/ASCAP): 0–50
- Cover art / packaging design: in-house (Chase + Tuthill)

Total Year 1 spend: under \$3,500. All of it sunk cost against future catalog value.

Year 2+ revenue model (when it starts):

- Streaming royalties (long tail, small)
- Sync licensing (the actual upside — film, TV, ads)
- Physical sales at shows (vinyl/CD merch table)
- Catalog licensing to other Big Muddy properties (Inn ambient, Radio bumpers, Touring promo)

The label is a catalog asset. We're not chasing hits. We're stockpiling masters we control forever.

The customer

Three customers, in order of priority:

1. **The Big Muddy ecosystem itself** — every Big Muddy property uses Big Muddy Records music. Inn lobby, Radio rotation, Touring intros, Magazine documentaries. Internal demand is the floor.
2. **Sync buyers** — music supervisors, ad agencies, indie film. Mississippi blues + Americana is undervalued and easy to license because we own everything.
3. **Listeners on streaming platforms** — Spotify, Apple Music, YouTube. Slow build via playlist placement and corridor SEO.

Not chasing radio. Not chasing chart position. Catalog and sync.

The 12-month plan

Q2 2026 (May–Jun)

- Pull the 3 Mechanical Bull masters off backup
- Get mastering quotes from 2 engineers
- Open DistroKid or Symphonic account under MBT entity
- Set up Big Muddy Records BMI publisher

Q3 2026 (Jul–Sep)

- Master record 1, ship to streaming
- Master record 2, ship to streaming
- Pitch to 5 sync agencies (Marmoset, Songtradr, Musicbed, Position Music, Pusher)
- Submit to 20 indie blues / Americana playlists

Q4 2026 (Oct–Dec)

- Master record 3, ship
- Sign Arrie Aslin band project formally (single-artist deal, not full label deal)
- First sync placement target — even \$200 counts as proof

Q1 2027 (Jan–Mar)

- Year-end review: did anything actually move?
 - Decide whether to sign a 3rd corridor artist or hold
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What we need to make it happen

People

- Chase: A&R, masters, label decisions
- Tracy: contracts, royalty splits, PRO admin (when she has bandwidth)
- Mastering engineer: outside hire, one project at a time

Money

- ~\$3,500 for the year. Comes out of MBT operating budget.

Tools

- Distributor account (DistroKid \$20/yr or Symphonic if we want better sync push)
- BMI publisher account
- Standard label split agreement template (Tracy + outside counsel review once)

Infrastructure

- Already have: domain, roster page, masters, in-house design

- Need: nothing external
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The risk

Three real risks. Naming them:

1. **Distraction risk.** Records eats Chase's attention without producing revenue. If it pulls focus from Touring or MBT, kill it or pause it.
2. **Sync market is crowded.** Every blues label pitches sync. Differentiation is "we own the corridor narrative" — unproven thesis.
3. **Catalog value depends on someone caring.** If Big Muddy as a brand never breaks out, the label is just three guys' records. The label only matters if the ecosystem matters.

Mitigation: keep spend low. Don't sign artists with advances. No physical pressing until streaming proves a song has legs.

Why it matters to the ecosystem

The label is an audience and brand multiplier, not a P&L line.

- **Touring uses it.** Bands on the Big Muddy Touring roster get a label home. That's a real recruitment edge against booking agents who have nothing to offer.
- **Radio uses it.** Big Muddy Radio rotation needs original masters we control to avoid licensing fees. Records supplies that.
- **Magazine uses it.** Album release = editorial story, video documentary, social campaign. One record fills a month of Magazine content.
- **Inn uses it.** Lobby playlist, dining room ambient, special-event playlists.
- **Brand uses it.** A label says we're serious about the music. A roster page without a label looks like a booking agent. A roster page with a label looks like an institution.

Every other module gets a 2x lift from having actual records to point at. That's the whole reason Records exists — not to make money in 2026, to make the rest of the ecosystem more credible while we build it.

Decision needed

None this quarter. Plan stands.